Scarlett Arriola and Yéléna Arakelian CART-263
Project 2: *Can You See Me?* Winter Term 2026
Artist Statement

Can You See Me? is an interactive single-player experience that explores distance, presence, and visibility within a three-dimensional digital environment. This second version builds on our first project by moving from a 2D interface into a 3D forest space, where the player searches for a hidden presence. The goal remains to locate the hidden avatar before the timer runs out, but the experience changes through the use of depth, camera perspective, and atmosphere. The hidden presence is not fully visible and appears only as a faint glow that becomes stronger as the player gets closer. This gradual reveal creates tension and uncertainty, encouraging players to rely on movement, attention, and spatial awareness. The hidden presence also periodically changes position, forcing the player to constantly reorient themselves within the space. The time limit adds pressure, reinforcing the urgency of locating the hidden presence before it disappears again.

The project is inspired by *Can You See Me Now?* by Blast Theory, where players move through space while tracking and being tracked by others. As Benford et al. explain, "gameplay emerges from players locating and pursuing each other through space" (Benford et al., 2006). While their work takes place across both physical and digital environments using GPS tracking, our version translates this idea into a fully digital space. Instead of navigating a real city, the player moves through a 3D environment where proximity still plays a central role. However, the addition of a third-person camera and environment changes how this proximity is experienced, making orientation and perspective part of the interaction.

Markus Montola's concept of pervasive games is also relevant, as he describes them as experiences that "expand the magic circle of play spatially, temporally, or socially" (Montola, 2005). Even though our project does not extend into physical space, the 3D environment creates a stronger sense of immersion and spatial awareness. The player must move carefully through the space, paying attention not only to position but also to what can and cannot be seen. Visibility is influenced by distance, but also by camera angle, lighting, and fog, making space feel more active rather than just a background.

Our process focused on adapting the core mechanics of the first project into a more complex environment. At first, the goal was simply to recreate the same idea in 3D, but we quickly realized that adding space changed how the game needed to function. The camera became an important part of the experience, so we implemented a third-person perspective that follows the player. This made the interaction more immersive while keeping it readable.

The project was built using Three.js, which allowed us to create and render a 3D scene directly in the browser. We set up the scene, lighting, and camera system, and imported a forest model to create the environment. Fog was added to reduce long-distance visibility and reinforce the idea

of partial perception. The visible player appears as a glowing form, while the hidden presence remains faint and becomes more visible based on distance. This keeps the focus on proximity and gradual discovery.

One of the main challenges was managing multiple systems at once. Compared to the first project, this version required handling movement in three dimensions, camera behavior, and the integration of the environment. We also had to adjust the scale of the world and the speed of movement so that the interaction felt balanced. Another challenge was tuning visual effects, especially fog and lighting, so the hidden presence remained difficult to see without making the game frustrating.

This project also connects to Jonah Brucker-Cohen's ideas in Locative Media Revisited, where he explains how digital systems tied to space influence how presence is experienced. Even though our project does not use real-world location data, it still shows how digital environments structure what can be seen and how interaction happens. Visibility depends on distance and movement, meaning the player must navigate space in order to reveal presence. In this way, interaction becomes less about simple control and more about understanding the environment.

Overall, this version expands our original idea into a more immersive experience. Moving from 2D to 3D allowed us to explore how depth, perspective, and atmosphere affect interaction. The core concept remains the same: proximity reveals presence, but the experience becomes more spatial and dynamic. What started as a simple mechanic developed into a deeper exploration of how space shapes perception and interaction in digital environments.

References

Benford, Steve, et al. 2006. *Can You See Me Now?* Blast Theory.

Montola, Markus. 2005. "Exploring the Edge of the Magic Circle: Defining Pervasive Games."

Brucker-Cohen, Jonah. 2014. *Locative Media Revisited.*

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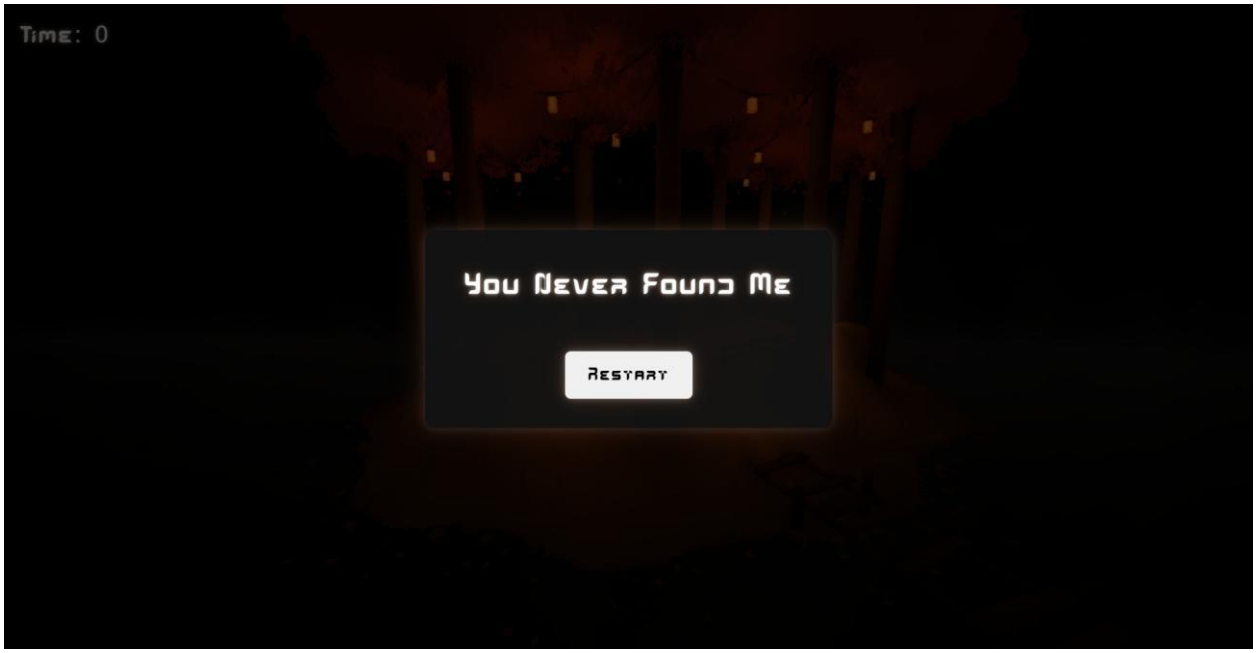

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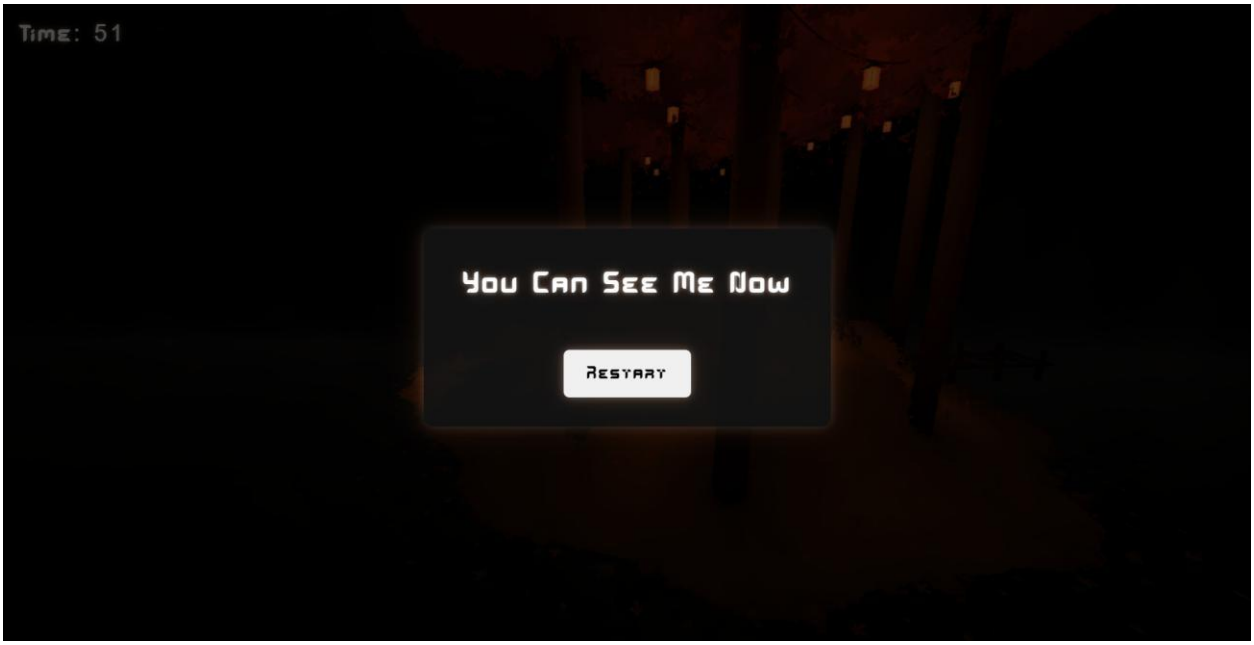
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